

Introduction: comprehensive world-pictures

PHIL UA-78 Metaphysics

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What is metaphysics?

τὰ μετὰ τὰ φυσικὰ βιβλία
(the books after the *Physics*)

Some unhelpful standard characterizations

Metaphysics is sometimes said to be the branch of philosophy that addresses questions about *reality*—how things are, how things *really* are, how the world is, etc.

- ▶ But all of philosophy—indeed, all of inquiry—is in one obvious sense concerned with reality.
- ▶ The question what we really ought to do belongs to ethics. The question what we really know belongs to epistemology. . .
- ▶ Adding that it addresses *fundamental* questions doesn't help much: doesn't all of philosophy? (Plus, lots of the questions don't seem so fundamental. . .)

A boring, but perhaps accurate definition

Metaphysics =

Philosophy – (Ethics + Political Philosophy + Aesthetics
+ Epistemology + Logic + Phil. of Mind
+ Phil. of Language + Phil. of Science + Phil. of Maths)

Let's forget about definition. Can we at least say something about central *themes* or *concerns*?

Metaphysics is centrally concerned with questions relevant to the formulation and evaluation of “comprehensive world-pictures”: systematic accounts of the nature of reality that claim to be in some sense *complete*.

- ▶ ‘There are such and such things, organized in such-and-such ways. *And that’s all.*’
- ▶ They can be more or less specific.
- ▶ Not so many of the questions are *about* particular comprehensive world-pictures! But very often they are interesting in part because of their potential to be relevant.

Comprehensive world-pictures

“By convention sweet, by convention bitter, by convention hot, by convention cold, by convention colour; but in reality atoms and void.”

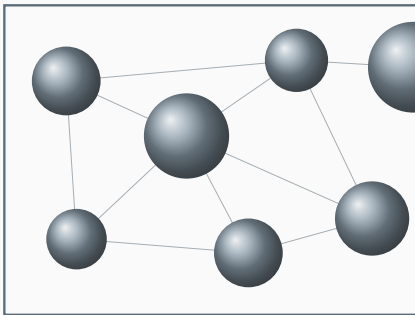
(Democritus, DK 68 B9)

A Democritean world-picture

Atomism

- ▶ There are atoms (let's forget about 'void' to keep things simple)
- ▶ Each atom has a certain shape and size, and is at a certain distance from every other atom
- ▶ The distances (and shapes and sizes?) change over time.

"...and that's all".



‘Isn’t that the concern of physics rather than philosophy?’

- ▶ There is a wide range of disparate arguments that might provide reasons to accept or reject a comprehensive world-picture.
- ▶ The specialised techniques of physicists are very relevant for evaluating some of these arguments. But there are other arguments which these techniques don’t help us evaluate. The task of dealing with those arguments falls to philosophy, by default.

Why the “pictures” are often so schematic

- ▶ Experiments in physics are more likely to be relevant to more detailed, specific comprehensive world-pictures.
- ▶ So it's not surprising that metaphysicians often talk about comprehensive world-pictures of a very un-detailed (or *schematic*) character.

Here's an example of an extremely schematic comprehensive world-picture:

There are objects that have fundamental properties and stand in fundamental relations. Each fundamental property is either had or not had by any given object. Each fundamental n -ary relation either holds or fails to hold between any given sequence of n objects. *And that's all.*

A somewhat more specific example

Physicalism

There are just physical objects having physical properties and relations, *and that's all*.

- ▶ But what counts as “physical”?
- ▶ Does ‘physical’ just mean ‘of interest to physicists’? But why shouldn’t physicists be interested in irreducible colours, or Cartesian minds, or . . .—if there are such things?
- ▶ Seems like there’s the potential here for a lot of pointless terminological disputes.

What's the use of studying pictures that are probably false?

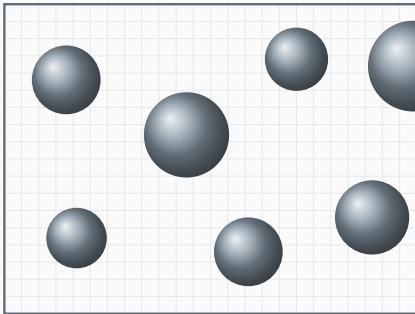
In part to avoid such disputes, it's often helpful to focus on fairly specific pictures such as the Democritean one, even when we expect them to be subject to serious objections coming from physics (or indeed from philosophy).

- ▶ Any work we do in clarifying what they mean will help in articulating alternatives.
- ▶ If there are good philosophical arguments against them, these will probably carry over to lots of other views, including some that fit better with real physics.
- ▶ Likewise, if they can be defended against philosophical arguments, the defences will probably carry over to lots of other views.

More examples

Atoms in space

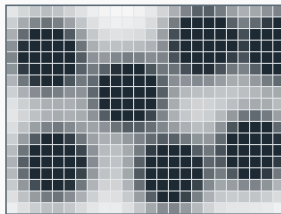
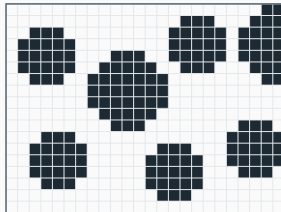
- ▶ There are atoms and points of space.
- ▶ Points of space stand in geometrical relations to one another so as to form a 3D volume.
- ▶ Each atom occupies some (continuous) points of space.
- ▶ The facts about which atoms occupy which points change over time.
- ▶ *And that's all.*



More examples

Full and Empty Space

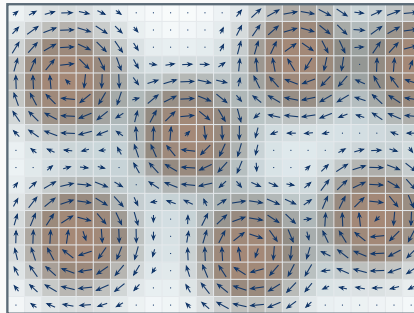
- ▶ There are points of space.
- ▶ They stand in geometrical relations to one another so as to form a 3D volume.
- ▶ Each is, moreover, either full or empty [or: has a certain degree of fullness].
- ▶ The facts about which ones are full and which ones are empty [or: how full they are] change over time.
- ▶ *And that's all.*



More examples

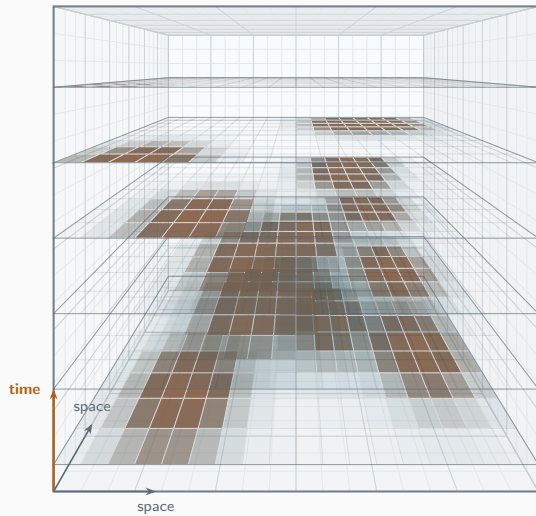
Fieldy Space

- ▶ There are points of space.
- ▶ They stand in geometrical relations to one another so as to form a 3D volume.
- ▶ They moreover differ as regards the magnitude and directions of certain fundamental *fields*.
- ▶ The facts about these magnitudes and directions change over time.
- ▶ *And that's all.*



Fieldy Spacetime

- ▶ There are points of spacetime.
- ▶ They stand in geometrical relations to one another so as to form a 4D volume with a contrast between 'temporal' and 'spatial' directions.
- ▶ They moreover differ as regards the magnitude and directions of certain fundamental *fields*.
- ▶ *And that's all.*



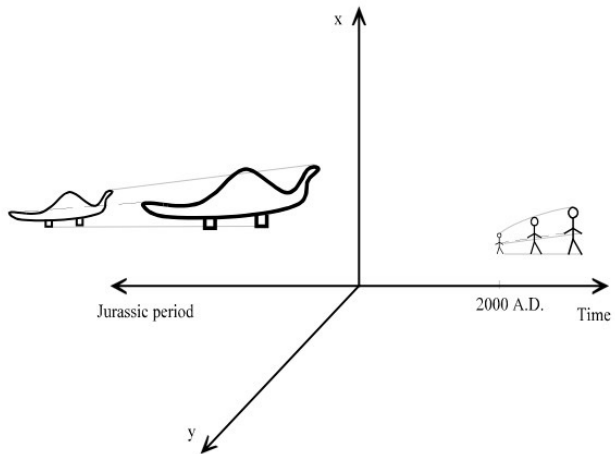


Diagram by Ted Sider.

Tables, atoms, and 'that's all'

A simple objection to atomism

There are tables [/planets/dogs/people]. And no table [/planet/dog/person] is an atom. So, it's not the case that there are only atoms. Your view is thus refuted!



Responding to the objection

Compare the following sillier sounding objection: there are large collections of atoms. But no atom is a large collection of atoms. So atomism is refuted!

- ▶ It's natural to feel that this is misunderstanding the intended meaning of the 'that's all' claim.
- ▶ Once we realize that for there to be a large collection of atoms just *is* for there to be very many atoms, we can see that the existence of large collections of atoms is compatible with the Democritean vision.
 - ▶ (Of course you *could* decide to interpret the 'that's all' in a super-demanding way that rules out there being any collections of atoms. I'm just suggesting that this isn't the *only* interpretation.)

Responding to the objection

- ▶ Similarly, the atomist vision seems compatible with there being *patterns* in the organization of the atoms.
- ▶ The atomist should say the same thing about how their view is compatible with there being tables/planets/dogs/people. The existence of these things just consists in atoms being spatially interrelated in certain complex ways.
 - ▶ NB., I'm not saying the atomist *has* to say that that tables are collections of atoms, or patterns in the organization of atoms; there may be other options. I'm using *collections* and *patterns* to illustrate a more generally applicable idea.

Radical eliminativist responses

A different response is to reject the premise and just say that *there are no tables*. (Or planets, or people. . . .)

In this course, we are not going to spend much time trying to make sense of views that say this sort of thing.

When philosophy gets weird

There's a long tradition of philosophers—especially metaphysicians—coming out with statements so radically at odds with “common sense” that they will find it hard to stick to their guns after they leave the “philosophy room”.

- ▶ ‘No material object is coloured’ (Galileo, C.L. Hardin)
- ▶ ‘No actions are right or wrong’ (J. L. Mackie)
- ▶ ‘Nothing causes anything’ (Bertrand Russell)
- ▶ ‘No-one believes or desires anything’ (Paul and Patricia Churchland)
- ▶ ‘No-one knows anything’ (Peter Unger)
- ▶ ‘No-one is able to do anything other than what they in fact do’ (“hard determinists”)

A common pattern

A: There aren't any tables—only atoms and void!

B: But just this morning, you said that there was a new table in the seminar room. Have you changed your mind since then?

A: No. When I said 'there is a new table in the seminar room', I was speaking in a *loose* way, and the belief I thereby express is compatible with the belief I just expressed with 'there aren't any tables'.

B: But why are you assuming that when ordinary people say things like 'There is a new table in the seminar room', they are *not* speaking in the so-called 'loose' way?

A common pattern

A: Hmm, I'm not sure. Suppose I said that they, like me, are speaking in the loose way?

B: Then we should say that this true thing you're calling the "loose" meaning of 'There is a new table in the seminar room' is the *literal* meaning of that sentence, and likewise for 'There are tables'.

A: Well OK. I suppose that when I earlier said 'There are no tables' I wasn't speaking according to the ordinary literal meaning, but in a technical "metaphysical" sense.

B: But wouldn't it be better practice for you to make your meaning clear by using some special technical "metaphysical" terminology, e.g. saying something like 'Tables aren't fundamental', to avoid the risk of misunderstanding?

Supervenience

This leaves us with a challenge: what *is* this elusive 'that's all' claim the Democritean wants to make? If it doesn't immediately commit us to wild claims like 'there are no tables', what content does it have?

A fruitful suggestion: at least, it includes a claim of *supervenience*.

Democritean supervenience (first pass)

All facts about the world are necessitated by:

- ▶ facts about what atoms there are
- ▶ facts about what shape and size each atom is (at each time)
- ▶ facts about how far apart any two atoms are (at each time)

Although not every fact is one of three groups, those three kinds of facts together necessitate all the other facts.

This may not capture the entire intended meaning of the 'that's all'. But at least it gives us something we can argue about!

The first order of business in the course is to get clearer about the notion of necessity being invoked here.